



Parent and community: Realistically, how much do toddlers struggle with accents?

Emily Shroads & Elizabeth K. Johnson
Dept. of Psychology, University of Toronto



Motivation

- Talker familiarity advantages are well-documented (e.g. Holmes et al., 2018; Barker & Newman, 2004) and interpreted as support for exemplar models of speech processing. However, some work suggests toddlers with non-local accented caregivers recognize words more readily in the dominant variety of their community, and not their parent's (Floccia et al., 2012). How can these be reconciled?
- Meanwhile, prior research suggests before 19 months, toddlers struggle to adapt to unfamiliar accents (Best et al., 2009; Mulak et al., 2013). But non-local accents vary in strength and distance from the local accent. Theoretical implications for adaptation processes and practical implications for children in linguistically-diverse communities are under-explored.

Aims

- 1) Collect a broad, representative sample of non-local accents of caregivers within a diverse community
- 2) Gain greater understanding of everyday speech processing by measuring toddlers' comprehension of these talkers in context of A) voice familiarity and B) unfamiliar-accent adaptation



Method

Participants: 16-month-olds primarily hearing English (>70%), split into two groups:

Multi-accent ($n = 25$; target $n = 32$)

- At least one **caregiver speaks a non-CanE variety** (other regional or foreign accent), and speaks in English to child >70% of the time
- Also **regularly hear CanE** in home and/or community

Mono-accent ($n = 18$; target $n = 32$)

- All main **caregivers speak Canadian English**
- Screened for exposure to any other varieties (from extended family, media, etc.)

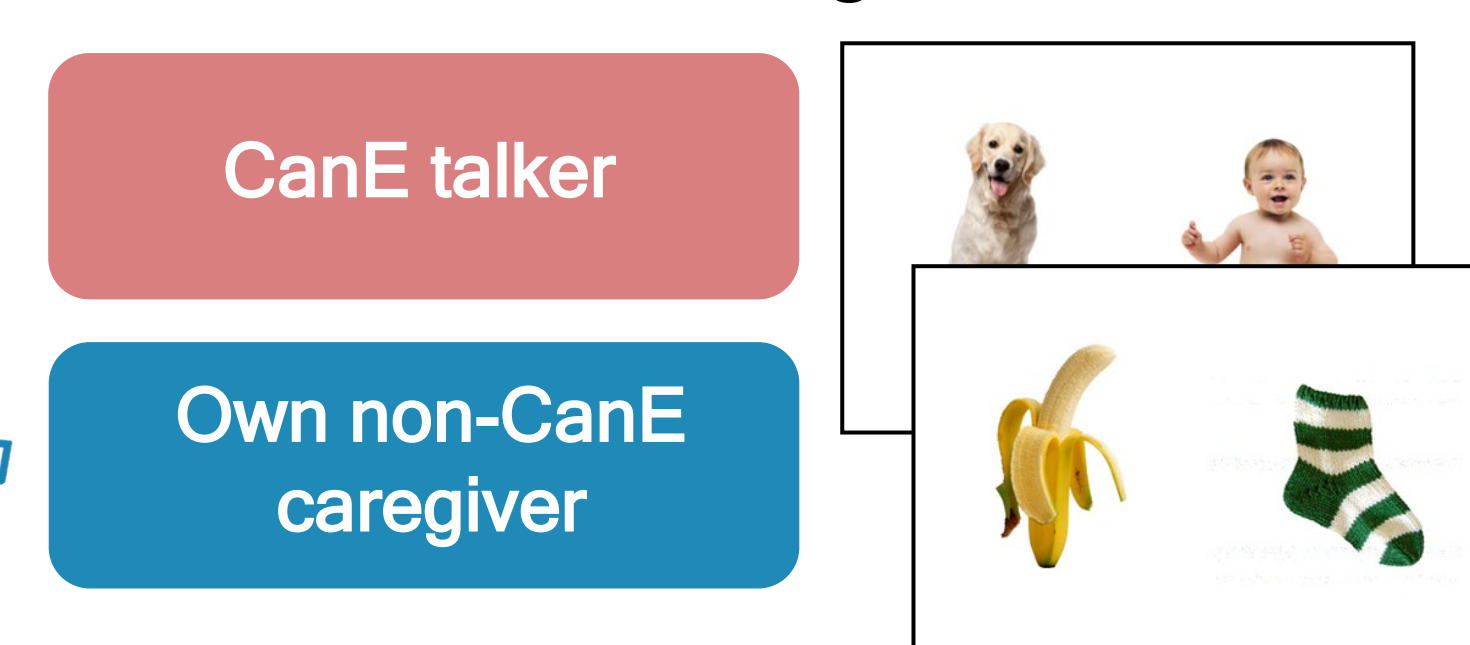
Procedure

1. Record caregiver



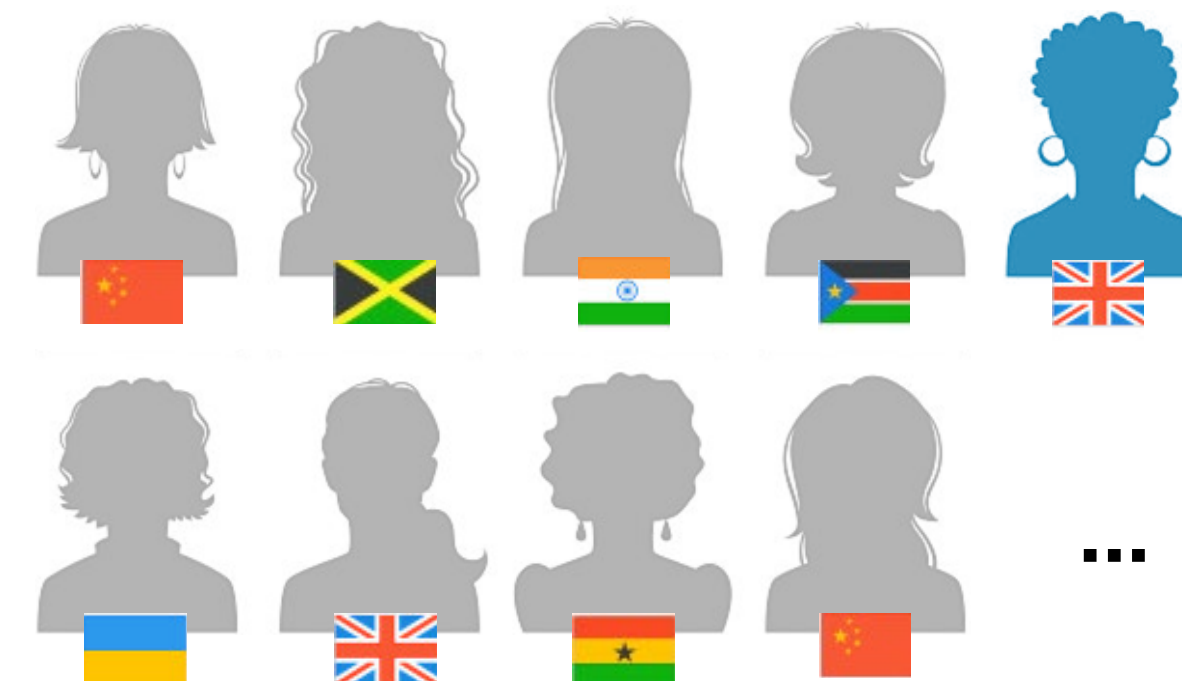
2. Eyetracking task

24 trials, alternating voice conditions

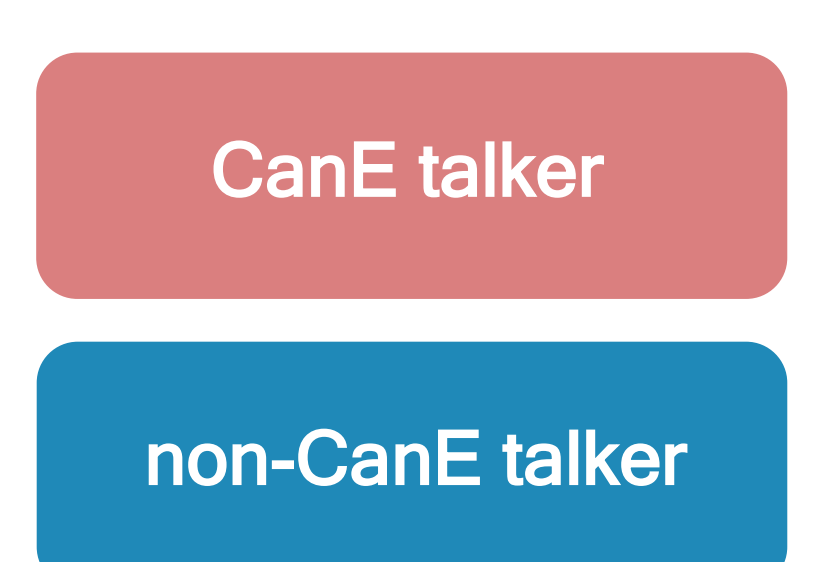


Procedure

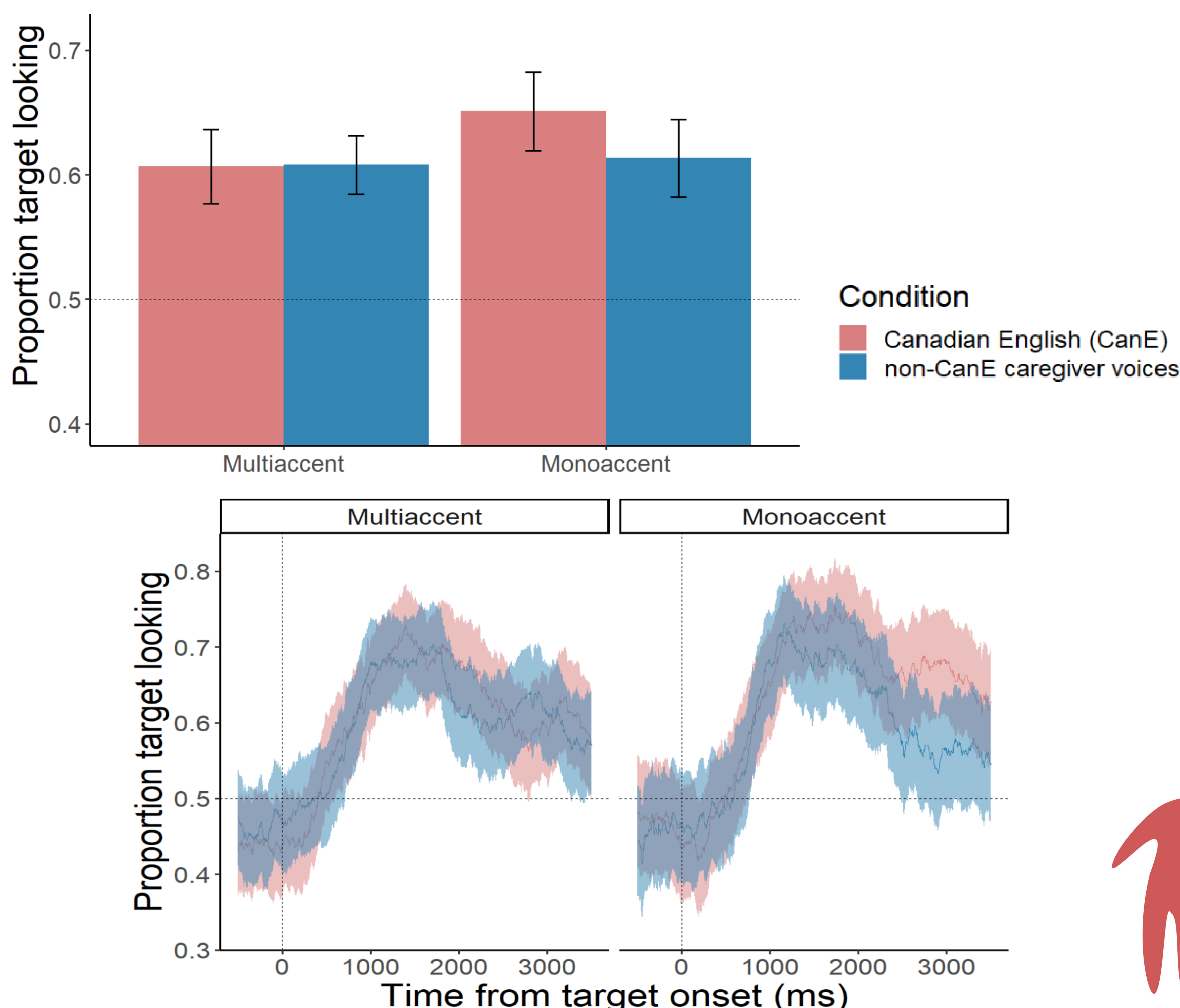
1. Assign unfamiliar-accent talker from multi-accent group caregivers



2. Eyetracking task



Results



Discussion

- Preliminary results suggest toddlers in both groups comprehend talkers with non-local accents.
- For children of these caregivers, voice familiarity advantages may act in balance with prioritized processing of the local accent, resulting in similar comprehension overall. However, voice familiarity is confounded with accent type in this design.
- For children unfamiliar with these accents, it is possible accent strength and/or distance plays a role in adaptation. We plan to examine these relationships when data collection is complete.

